



R. K. NITHIN

it was, will always be a career-defining medal for Neeraj. "It is, of course, the one I am most proud of. Not the World Championship. The Olympics is what made Neeraj great. All his sponsorships and fame happened because of it, without which he wouldn't have his millions. Maybe he would still have won the Worlds, but the Olympics is his greatest achievement," says Klaus.

But Klaus clarifies that it didn't define him. "Nothing changed with Neeraj after the Olympic gold, and again I think that is because of his motivation for the sport. A lot of athletes get into the sport maybe because they wanted money or a job. But for Neeraj that wasn't the

case, and I think that's where the difference is. So even though there was a lot of money, and there were all these girls who wanted to marry him, he didn't get distracted. I think the only thing that changed was that he got older and even more mature," says Klaus.

But while he didn't succumb to distractions, Neeraj was limited by injuries. Some have been well documented — like the elbow he had surgery on in 2019 and the recurrent groin injury that's bothered him over many years. There are also lesser-known ailments Klaus reveals — such as the time Neeraj fractured his little finger while practising hurdle jumps before the 2023 Worlds. **But perhaps Klaus's toughest moment came in 2022, he says, when Neeraj picked up a groin injury during a practice session.**

"He thought this was one of his best-ever workouts when it happened. He had warmed up well too. And he was throwing with a lot of power when he picked this up. When he got that, I felt it was going to be difficult to finish the season. We went to see a lot of specialists in Dubai, Italy and France," says Klaus.

Klaus credits Neeraj's eventual recovery to physiotherapist Ishan Marwaha's "creative rehabilitation work". However, he admits the injury did limit Neeraj's performance and says he wonders if he could have managed Neeraj's training better.

"I wonder if perhaps he was overloaded in training. That might have been a problem. But Neeraj was always someone who pushed himself. He always wanted to have a really good workout. That was his philosophy. I think 90 percent of his workouts were really hard ones. In all our time together, I remember there was just one day when he felt tired from throwing the day before and had to take a break," says Klaus.

Unfortunately for Neeraj, this time coincided with the rise of Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem, who would go on to beat him with a record throw at the Paris Games.

"I knew before Paris that it was going to be very difficult to win a second gold. Especially if you have to

deal with athletes like Arshad. We knew Arshad had an injury because he had surgery, but right after that he was throwing over 90 metres! He's not a very fast thrower but he has textbook technique. I knew it was going to be difficult after he got that 92-metre throw (in his second throw of the Olympic final), but I thought Neeraj had that capacity. He got an 89-metre throw as well, but it wasn't enough. I am not disappointed.

"It wasn't that we did something wrong. Neeraj didn't have his best day, and that coincided with Arshad having a near perfect day. You can't be angry at Neeraj for this. You must accept it. Neeraj did so as well and he congratulated Arshad for it," says Klaus.

Klaus says he still keeps in touch with his former trainee. "We don't speak, but we do send messages to each other. I congratulated him after he threw 90m (in the Doha Diamond League)," says Klaus.

That throw, says Klaus, is a testament to how Neeraj — who now trains under world record holder Jan Zelezny — is still getting better. "I think there was good wind in Doha which helped the throw, but what really stood out for me was Neeraj's run-up speed. He was so fast. It was a very powerful run-up," says Klaus.

Neeraj has spoken of being injury-free, especially regarding the persistent groin issue, and Klaus says that has played an important role behind his runway speed. "The fact that his groin injury is healed doesn't really impact his running speed because the groin really gets activated at the crossover stage which follows the run-up. But at the same time, you won't run in so fast if you are afraid that your groin can't handle that power. Being injury-free is allowing him to run faster now. He's more confident that he can turn with that speed," says Klaus.

Despite becoming only the 26th man to breach the 90m barrier, Neeraj was beaten to first place by Julian Weber in Doha. He himself called the moment a bittersweet one, but Klaus believes he'll recover